Simon Bolivar: Bolivar belonged to an old aristocratic Creole family in Caracas. He was of fundamental importance to the movement as an ideologue and military leader. In his most famous "Jamaica Letter" (written during one of his periods of exile, 1815), Bolívar affirmed his undying faith in the cause of independence, even in the face of the patriots' repeated defeats. While critiquing Spanish colonialism, Bolívar held the view that the only path for the former colonies was the establishment of an autonomous and centralised republican government. The type of republic that he eventually espoused was very much an oligarchic one. He believed that a virtuous governing system would not be possible if the nation was divided by ethnicity. Bolivar was an inspiring figure to left-wing and emancipatory movements in Latin America even in the latter half of the twentieth century.

Mexican Revolution

The independence of Mexico came late. Mexico had a powerful segment of Creoles and Peninsulars, who were the colonial masters born in Spain or Portugal. For many of the powerful in Mexican society, a break with Spain meant a loss of traditional status and power. Between 1808 and 1810, Peninsulars had acted aggressively to preserve Spain's power in the region. Rejecting the notion of a congress that would address the question of governance in the absence of the Spanish king, leading Peninsulars in Mexico City deposed the viceroy and persecuted Creoles. They then welcomed weaker viceroys whom they knew they could dominate. Peninsulars' efforts could not, however, prevent the emergence of an independence struggle.

The revolution in Mexico was led by a catholic priest, Miguel Hidalgo. He supported the poor people of Mexico and sympathised with the poor living conditions of Native Americans. His emotional speeches at the Church of Dolores called for independent Mexico. He led a revolutionary army consisting of Mestizos



Miguel Hidalgo



Jose Maria Morelos

against the army of Spain and Creoles. However, he was defeated and killed in 1811. Later the movement was led by Jose Maria Morelos, who declared independence from Spain in 1813. He was also defeated in 1815.

The Creoles or the wealthy merchants were watching the developments in Spain where a movement to overthrow monarchy and to make a new constitution was afoot. Thinking that this might reduce the power of the Creoles, they declared independence in 1821. It is interesting to note that the person who led the movement was the same officer who defeated the army of Maria Morelos. He declared himself as the emperor whose ruthless rule was overthrown finally. In 1824 Mexico declared itself as a republic.

Independence of Brazil



Dom Pedro

Brazil was a colony of Portugal. When Napoleon invaded Portugal in 1808, the Portuguese emperor Dam Joao (John VI) fled to Brazil. He had developed the colony in all aspects by introducing land reforms and establishing military, medical and art schools. Even after the defeat of Napoleon, the Portuguese ruler continued to stay in Brazil. But when his power was challenged he decided to go to Portugal leaving the colony of Brazil in the hands of his son Dom Pedro.

The reliance of the Brazilian upper classes on African slavery favoured their continued ties with Portugal. Plantation owners depended

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